

Avalon-MM Firewall IP Core

User Guide

IP core	<code>altera_avalon_mm_firewall</code>
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1. About the Avalon-MM Firewall IP Core

The Avalon-MM Firewall IP core is a bump-in-the-wire component that sits between a bus master and a peripheral you want to protect. It enforces an allow-list on every transaction, and guarantees the master always receives a complete response even when the protected peripheral stops answering.

There is no equivalent core in the Intel FPGA IP catalog. AMD/Xilinx ship an AXI Protocol Firewall, but that core polices protocol legality and has no address-range access control; the two are complementary rather than equivalent.

The core is fully burst-capable. It is a pass-through gate rather than a store-and-forward buffer: a permitted transaction reaches the protected peripheral with **no added latency and no data storage anywhere in the core**, so a DMA engine behind the firewall runs at the same rate it would without it. A refused transaction never reaches the peripheral at all, and is answered by the firewall itself.

Note

A companion core, `altera_axi4_lite_firewall`, provides the same function for AXI4-Lite. That core is single-transaction and non-bursting: a bursting master in front of it is split into single beats by Platform Designer's burst adapter, and each beat pays a six-cycle cost. Use this core for any master that bursts.

1.1 Features

- **Allow-list access control.** Up to 64 software-programmable address windows, each with independent read, write and burst permission. Any address not described by a valid window is denied. The core is secure at reset: access control is enabled and the rule table is empty, so everything is denied until software says otherwise.
- **Burst-aware range checking.** The first *and last* byte of every transaction are checked against the same matched window, so a burst cannot begin inside a permitted window and run past its end.
- **Per-window burst capability.** A window can permit single accesses while refusing bursts, for peripherals that cannot handle them.
- **Fault isolation with a hard guarantee that the master never hangs.** If the protected peripheral stops making progress, the core completes the outstanding transaction itself — synthesising the read beats it owes, or consuming the write beats it must — and walls the peripheral off.
- **Protocol-safe abandonment.** The core never withdraws a command whose `waitrequest` handshake has not completed. Such a command is frozen and held until software explicitly authorises discarding it.
- **Zero added latency** on permitted transactions, with full burst throughput of one beat per cycle.
- **Pipelined reads**, with a configurable outstanding-beat budget.
- **Separate control port**, so configuration and status are never subject to the firewall's own rules and remain reachable when the data path is isolated.
- **Level interrupt** on any enabled fault, with per-source masking, and a latched record of the offending address, direction, cause and burst length.
- **Nios II HAL driver** provided, including the full recovery sequence.

1.2 Device Family Support

The core is plain synthesisable SystemVerilog with no device primitives, no vendor-specific attributes and no inferred memory. It is expected to compile for any Intel/Altera family supported by your Quartus Prime installation.

Caution

Device support has not been characterised on hardware. See [Section 9](#).

1.3 Resource Utilization

Not characterised. The design is a rule table plus comparators and a handful of counters; the dominant term is `NUM_RULES`, which instantiates two `ADDR_WIDTH`-wide magnitude comparators per rule per channel.

Caution

No synthesis results are quoted anywhere in this document. A number here would be a guess, and a guess in a resource table is indistinguishable from a measurement.

1.4 Release Information

Item	Value
Version	1.0
CORE_INFO version field	0x0100
Release date	August 2026
Ordering code	None — source-provided

2. Getting Started

2.1 Installing the IP Core

1. Clone or copy the `altera-ip-cores` repository to your machine.
2. In Quartus Prime, choose **Tools ► Options ► IP Catalog Search Locations** and add the repository's **top-level** directory (the one containing `altera_avalon_mm_firewall/`, not that directory itself).
3. In Platform Designer, choose **File ► Refresh System**.

The core appears in the IP Catalog as **Avalon-MM Firewall**, under *Bridges and Adapters / Custom*.

Note

Hand-written `_hw.tcl` syntax has drifted across Quartus releases. If the component does not import cleanly, package it with the Component Editor instead: add the three files under `rtl/` as synthesis files with `avl_mm_firewall_pkg.sv` **first** in the list and `avl_mm_firewall_top.sv` as the top-level file, then click **Analyze Synthesis Files**. Signal analysis groups the `s0_*`, `m0_*` and `csr_*` ports automatically. The one property it cannot infer is `bridgesToMaster` on `s0` — set it by hand in *Signals & Interfaces*, then **Finish** to export an `_hw.tcl` correct for your exact toolchain.

2.2 Adding the Core to a Platform Designer System

The core is inserted into an existing connection, between a master and the peripheral being protected:

1. Instantiate **Avalon-MM Firewall**.
2. Disconnect the master from the peripheral.
3. Connect the master to `s0`, and `m0` to the peripheral.
4. Connect the CPU's data master to `csr`, and assign it a base address.
5. Connect `clock` and `reset` to the system clock and reset network.
6. Connect `irq` to a CPU interrupt input.

Note

Because `s0` declares `bridgesToMaster m0`, `s0`'s address space is `m0`'s. **The protected peripheral's address does not change when you insert the firewall.** Existing software and existing address assignments continue to work.

2.3 Required Connections

Interface	Connect to	Required
<code>clock</code>	System clock	Yes
<code>reset</code>	System reset	Yes
<code>s0</code>	The master whose accesses are to be policed	Yes
<code>m0</code>	The peripheral being protected	Yes
<code>csr</code>	A processor data master	Yes — without it the rule table stays empty and everything is denied
<code>irq</code>	A processor interrupt input	Recommended. Without it, violations are visible only by polling STATUS

Additionally, and not a Platform Designer connection: the protected peripheral's reset must be controllable by software. The core does not drive it, but recovery from a timeout requires asserting it. A Platform Designer reset bridge under software control, or a PIO bit, is sufficient. See [Section 3.7](#).

Caution

A system with no software-controllable peripheral reset cannot complete the recovery sequence. A single timeout then takes the protected peripheral out of service until the whole system is reset.

2.4 Simulating the IP Core

A self-checking testbench, SystemVerilog assertions and two simulation flows are provided. None requires a Quartus licence.

```
# Verilator: strict elaboration, lint, parameter sweep, then the regression
# run twice - once per USE_WRITE_RESPONSE setting.
pip install pyslang
simulation/verilator/run_sim.sh
```

```
# Questa: adds code, assertion and cover-directive coverage.
cd simulation/questa
do run_sim.tcl
```

```
# Icarus: functional tests only; -DICARUS omits the assertion bind.
iverilog -g2012 -DICARUS -o tb.out rtl/avl_mm_firewall_pkg.sv \
    rtl/avl_mm_firewall_regs.sv rtl/avl_mm_firewall_top.sv tb/avl_mm_firewall_tb.sv
vvp tb.out
```

2.5 Files Provided

File	Purpose
avl_mm_firewall_hw.tcl	Platform Designer component description
rtl/avl_mm_firewall_pkg.sv	Response codes, verdict enumeration, rule layout. Compile first
rtl/avl_mm_firewall_top.sv	Data path, burst handling, timeout and isolation
rtl/avl_mm_firewall_regs.sv	Rule table, status, interrupt, control port
tb/avl_mm_firewall_tb.sv	Self-checking testbench and peripheral model
tb/avl_mm_firewall_sva.sv	Assertions and cover points
avl_mm_firewall_sw.tcl	Nios II BSP driver description. Required for the BSP to find the driver
inc/altera_avalon_mm_firewall_regs.h	Register offsets, accessors and bit masks. Depends only on <io.h>
HAL/inc/altera_avalon_mm_firewall.h	Driver API and BSP auto-initialisation macros
HAL/src/altera_avalon_mm_firewall.c	Nios II HAL driver
simulation/verilator/run_sim.sh	Licence-free regression
simulation/questa/run_sim.tcl	Regression with coverage

3. Functional Description

3.1 Block Diagram

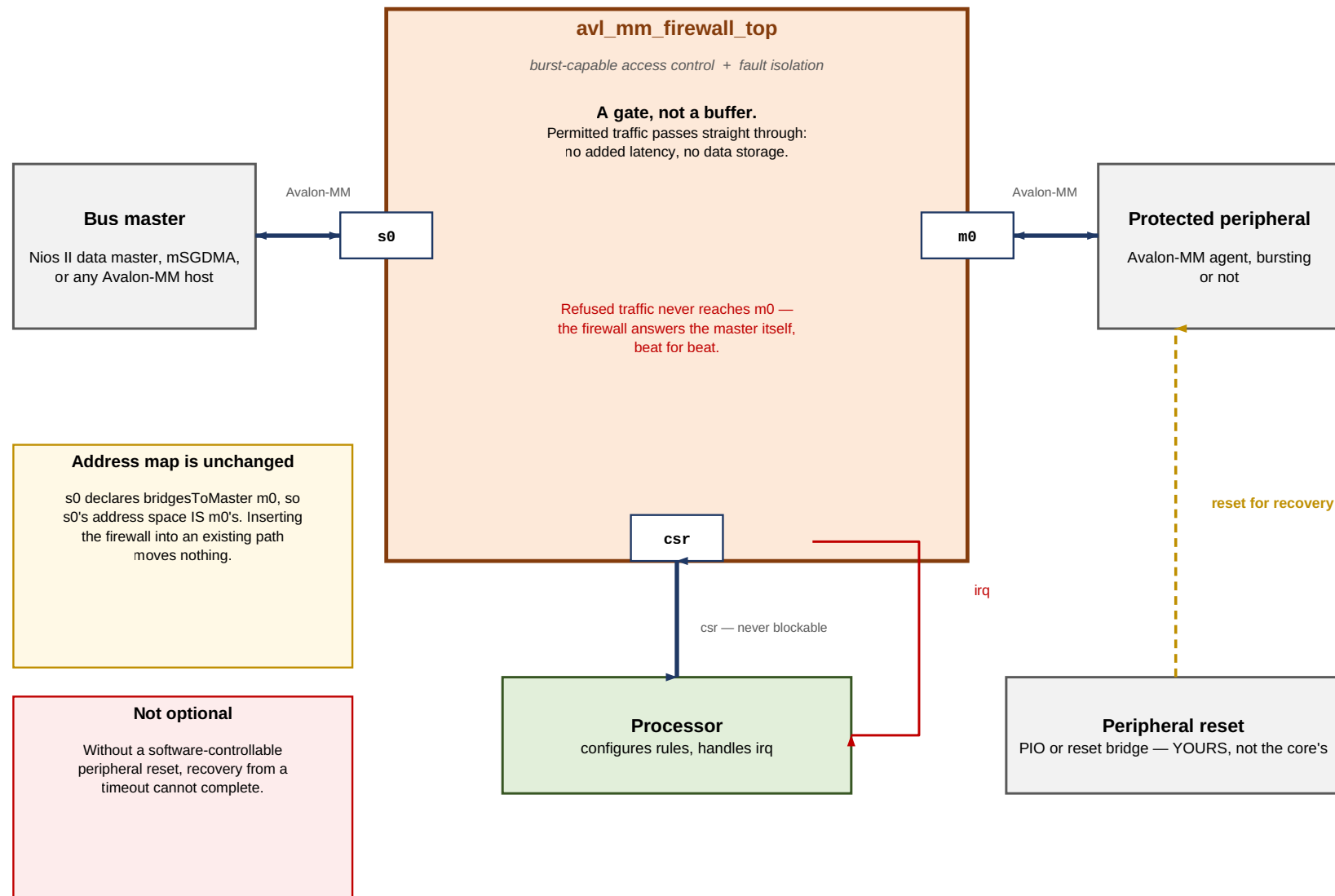
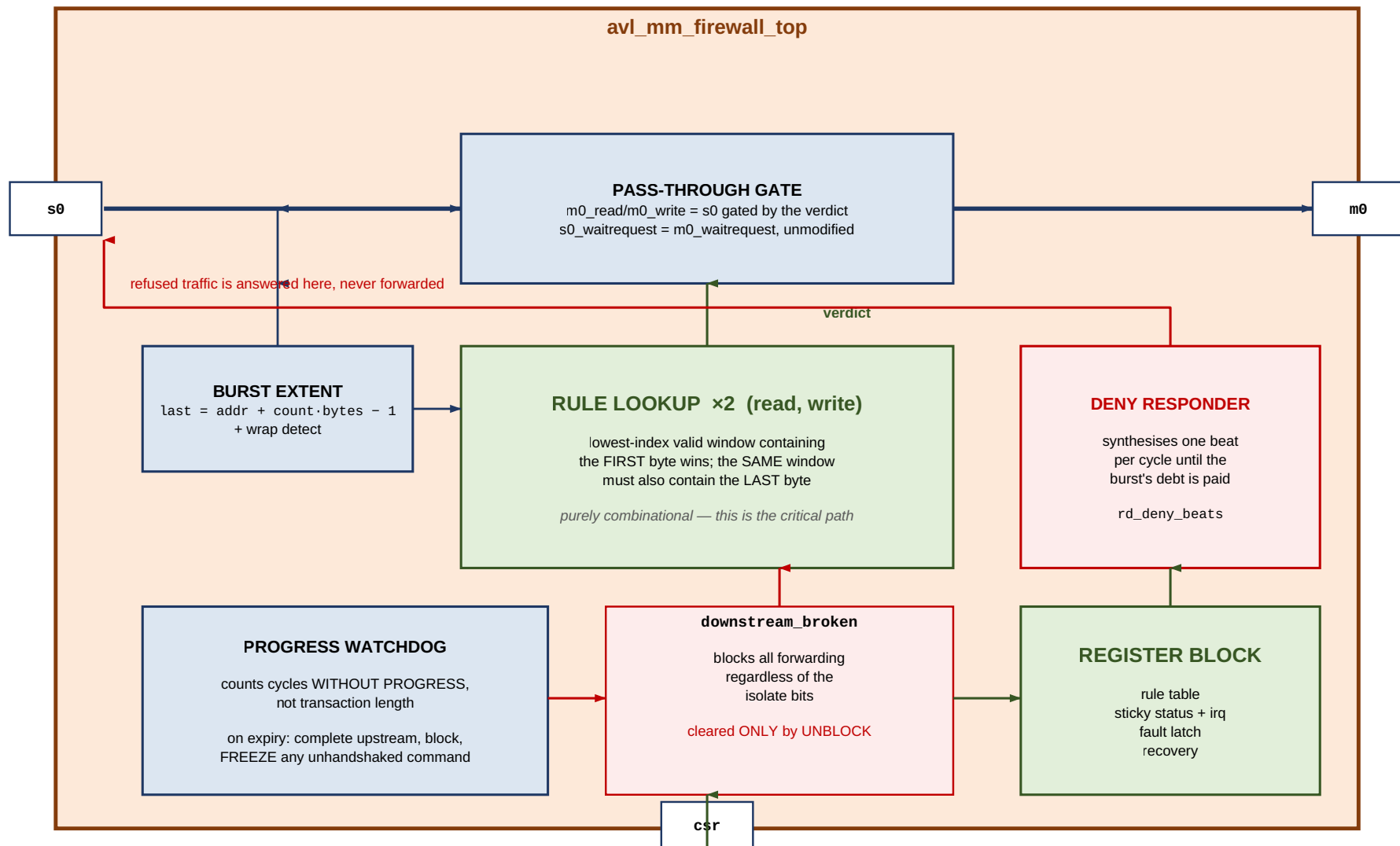


Figure 1. System context

The core presents three Avalon-MM interfaces and one interrupt:

- `s0` — Avalon-MM agent (slave). Faces the master. Byte-addressed, bursting, pipelined reads.
- `m0` — Avalon-MM host (master). Faces the protected peripheral. Same width and burst capability as `s0`.
- `csr` — Avalon-MM agent. 32-bit, word-addressed, fixed read latency of 1, never asserts `waitrequest`.
- `irq` — level interrupt.



There is no data storage anywhere in the data path. Refused traffic is the only thing the core generates itself.

Figure 2. Internal architecture

Internally the core is a *gate*, not a buffer. There is no data storage anywhere in the data path. A permitted transaction's `read / write` is forwarded to `m0` gated by the rule lookup, `s0_waitrequest` is `m0_waitrequest` unmodified, and read data flows back untouched. A refused transaction never reaches `m0`, and the core answers the master itself.

3.2 Access Control

Every transaction presented on `s0` is checked against a table of `NUM_RULES` address windows. Each window has:

Field	Meaning
<code>RULE_BASE[i]</code>	First byte of the window, inclusive
<code>RULE_LIMIT[i]</code>	Last byte of the window, inclusive
<code>RULE_PERM[i].VALID</code>	The window is ignored entirely when clear
<code>RULE_PERM[i].READ_ALLOW</code>	Reads are permitted
<code>RULE_PERM[i].WRITE_ALLOW</code>	Writes are permitted
<code>RULE_PERM[i].BURST_ALLOW</code>	<code>burstcount > 1</code> is permitted

The model is **default-deny**. An address that falls in no valid window is refused. Out of reset the whole table is invalid, so the core denies everything until software programs it.

Setting `CTRL.GLOBAL_ENABLE` to 0 puts the core in **bypass mode**, where the rule check is skipped and every transaction is forwarded.

Caution

Bypass mode disables *access control*, not *fault isolation*. A peripheral the core has already walled off after a timeout stays walled off in bypass mode. This is deliberate: the two are separate jobs, and a wedged peripheral is a bus-level hazard regardless of whether you are policing addresses.

3.3 Burst Handling

Bursts are where a firewall is easiest to get subtly wrong, and four properties of Avalon-MM shape the design.

A refused transaction must still be completed. Avalon-MM has no abort. A refused read burst of `N` beats must still produce `N` beats of `readdatavalid`, or the master waits forever; a refused write burst must still have all `N` beats consumed. The core therefore becomes the responder for refused traffic: it accepts the command immediately — never stalling it — and synthesises the whole burst's worth of error responses itself. Read beats returned this way carry zero data, not stale data.

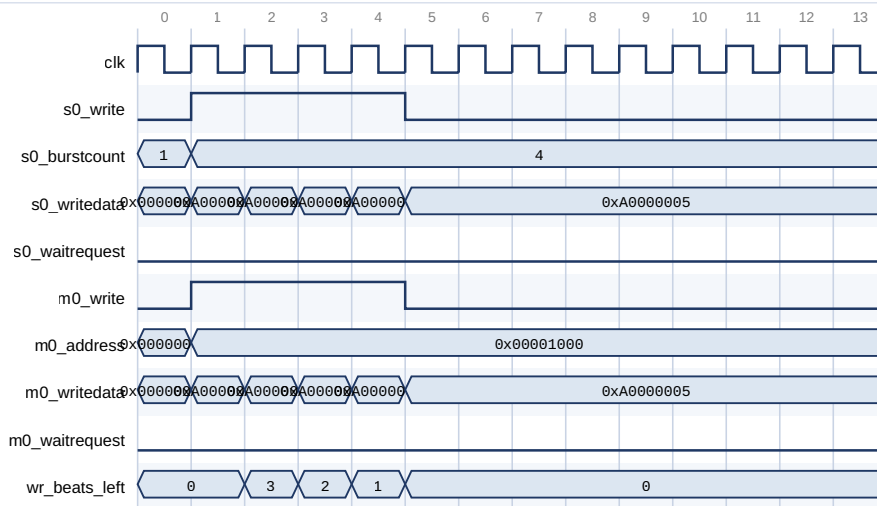
The whole burst range is checked. The core computes the last byte the transaction will touch:

```
last_byte = address + burstcount x (DATA_WIDTH/8) - 1
```

and requires that the window matched by `address` also contains `last_byte`. A burst that begins inside a permitted window and runs past its end is refused. A burst that would wrap past the top of the address space is likewise refused rather than being allowed to alias to low addresses.

Adjacent windows do not merge. A burst crossing the boundary between two abutting permitted windows is refused, even when both windows permit the access. Permissions are per-window, and such a burst would have to satisfy both.

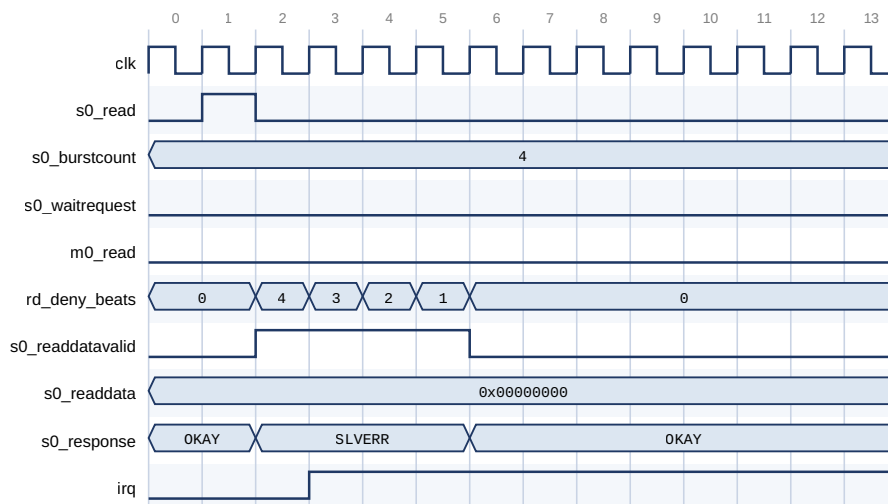
The verdict is latched for the whole burst. On beats 2..`N` of an Avalon-MM write burst the master presents only `writedata`; the address is not meaningful. The verdict formed at the first beat governs the entire burst.



A 4-beat write burst into a window that permits writes and bursts.

m0 is s0 gated by the rule lookup: the same beats, the same cycle, no buffering. s0_waitrequest is m0_waitrequest unmodified, so the core adds no latency at all. The address is meaningful only on the first beat; wr_beats_left is what holds the burst together, and the verdict formed at beat 1 governs all four.

Figure 3. Permitted burst — pass-through



A 4-beat read burst into a write-only window. m0_read never asserts - the protected peripheral is not touched at all.

The command is ACCEPTED immediately (waitrequest stays low) rather than stalled: stalling it would move the hang from the peripheral into the firewall.

Avalon-MM has no way to refuse, so the core owes the master four beats and synthesises them itself. rd_deny_beats is that debt counting down. Data is driven to zero, not left stale.

Figure 4. Refused burst — the firewall answers

3.4 Rule Evaluation

The rule lookup is purely combinational and duplicated, once for the write channel and once for the read channel, so both get an independent answer in the same cycle.

Priority between rules: the lowest-index valid window containing the **start address** wins. Windows need not be disjoint; place more specific windows at lower indices if you use overlapping ranges.

Priority between checks within the matched window is *direction before extent*:

1. Does any valid window contain the start address? If not — ADDR_VIOLATION .
2. Does that window permit this direction? If not — PERM_VIOLATION .
3. Does that window also contain the last byte? If not — BURST_VIOLATION (type BURST_RANGE).
4. If this is a burst, does that window permit bursts? If not — BURST_VIOLATION (type BURST_DENIED).

Direction is checked first so that a write burst into a read-only window reports a permission violation rather than a confusing burst error.

Note

All `NUM_RULES` comparators are in the combinational path from `s0_address` to `m0_read/m0_write` and `s0_waitrequest`. This is the critical path of the core. Use the smallest `NUM_RULES` that covers your address map.

3.5 Error Responses

Cause	response	STATUS bit	FAULT_INFO.TYPE
Address in no valid window	DECODEERROR (2'b11)	ADDR_VIOLATION	1
Window does not permit this direction	SLAVEERROR (2'b10)	PERM_VIOLATION	2
Downstream stopped making progress	SLAVEERROR	TIMEOUT_ERROR	3
Burst extends past the matched window	DECODEERROR	BURST_VIOLATION	4
Window does not permit bursts	SLAVEERROR	BURST_VIOLATION	5
Rejected because the core is isolated or blocked	SLAVEERROR	(none)	(none)

A rejection *while blocked* deliberately raises no new fault. The timeout that caused the block already latched one; re-latching on every subsequent rejected access would overwrite the `FAULT_ADDR` that diagnoses the original problem.

Caution

With `USE_RESPONSE` set to 0 the `response` signal is not present on the interfaces. Refused reads still return the correct number of beats, but they read as zeros with no error indication, and refused writes complete silently. The violation is then visible only through `irq` and `STATUS`. Leave `USE_RESPONSE` enabled unless your master genuinely cannot accept the signal.

3.6 Fault Isolation and Timeout

`TIMEOUT_VALUE` sets the number of clock cycles the core will tolerate **without progress** on a forwarded transaction. Progress means a beat accepted, a beat of read data returned, or a write response received.

Note

The timeout measures cycles without progress, not total transaction duration. This matters for a bursting core: timing whole transactions would force `TIMEOUT_VALUE` to be scaled by the longest burst in the system, which makes it useless as a hang detector. A 128-beat burst against a slow peripheral is progress; a peripheral that has not moved a beat in `N` cycles is not.

When the budget is exhausted the core:

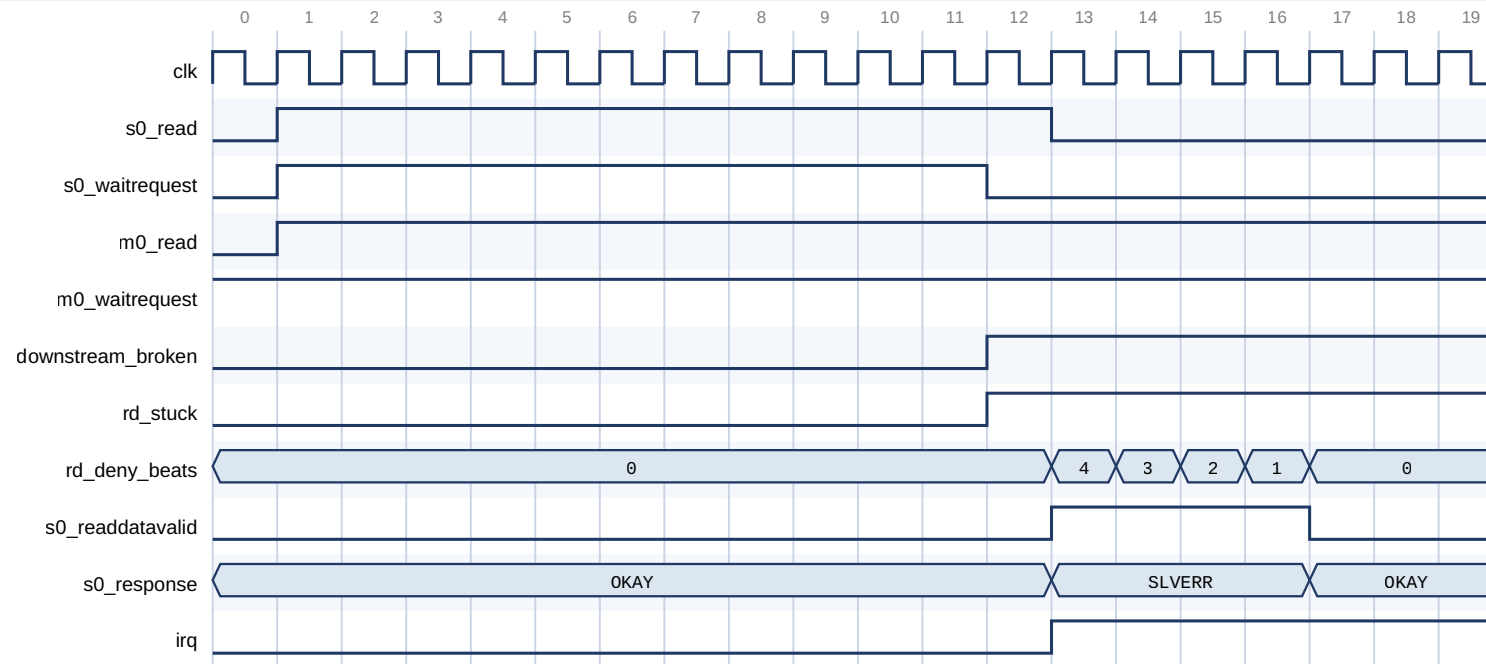
1. **Completes the upstream transaction immediately.** Read beats still owed become synthesised `SLAVEERROR` beats; remaining write beats are consumed and discarded. The master is released and never hangs.
2. **Latches an internal blocked state**, which refuses all further forwarding regardless of the isolate control bits. This is required for protocol safety and does not depend on `CTRL.AUTO_ISOLATE_EN`, which governs only the visible `ISOLATED` status bit.
3. **Freezes any `m0` command whose `waitrequest` never fell**, holding it asserted rather than withdrawing it.
4. **Abandons work on both channels.** A timeout on either channel gives up on the peripheral entirely. Letting one channel keep forwarding into a peripheral the other has just abandoned would also allow a frozen `m0_read` to coexist with a live `m0_write`, which Avalon-MM forbids.

Point 3 deserves emphasis. Avalon-MM requires a host to hold `read` or `write` asserted until `waitrequest` deasserts. Withdrawing it can wedge the interconnect between the firewall and the peripheral, not merely the peripheral. So the core distinguishes two kinds of damage:

	Avoidable?	What the core does
A forwarded burst abandoned part-way, leaving the peripheral waiting for beats	No — the master upstream must be released, and Avalon-MM has no burst-abort	Accepts it; this is why the peripheral reset in recovery is mandatory
A command withdrawn before its handshake completed	Yes	Never does it. The command is frozen and held until <code>RECOVERY.UNBLOCK</code>

`STATUS` exposes what is outstanding so software can sequence recovery:

Bit	Meaning
<code>WR_BUSY</code> / <code>RD_BUSY</code>	The peripheral owes the core a write completion / read beats
<code>WR_CMD_STUCK</code> / <code>RD_CMD_STUCK</code>	The core is holding a command the peripheral never accepted
<code>BLOCKED</code>	Forwarding is refused; only <code>RECOVERY.UNBLOCK</code> clears it



The peripheral holds `m0_waitrequest` high forever. `TIMEOUT_VALUE` is 10 cycles in this capture; a real system uses thousands.

On expiry the core completes the transaction upstream itself - four SLAVEERROR beats - so the master never hangs, and latches `downstream_broken`.

`m0_read` STAYS ASSERTED. Avalon-MM forbids withdrawing a command before waitrequest falls; `rd_stuck` records that the core is holding one. Only `RECOVERY.UNBLOCK` may drop it.

Figure 5. Timeout and recovery

3.7 Recovery Sequence

Recovery is an explicit software sequence. The core does not attempt it automatically, because step 4 requires resetting a peripheral the core does not own.

1. Stop issuing transactions to s0.
2. Write 1 to the sticky STATUS bits. (acknowledge; also releases the auto-isolate latch)
3. Poll STATUS until WR_BUSY and RD_BUSY clear - WITH A BOUND.
4. ASSERT the protected peripheral's reset and HOLD it (≥ 16 clocks).
5. Write RECOVERY.UNBLOCK - while the reset is still asserted.
6. Release the protected peripheral's reset.
7. Resume.

Caution

Steps 5 and 6 are in this order deliberately. UNBLOCK is what withdraws a frozen m0 command. If the peripheral is already out of reset when that write lands, it can complete the frozen command's handshake first — latching a transaction the firewall has already reported to the master as failed. Withdrawing the command while the peripheral cannot see the bus removes that possibility, and costs nothing.

Caution

Bound the poll in step 3. WR_BUSY and RD_BUSY mean *the peripheral owes us something*, and a peripheral that accepted a command and then died owes it forever. An unbounded poll hangs exactly when recovery matters most. Treat the bits as advisory: clear means no late response can still be in flight and the reset is unambiguously safe; still set means reset anyway and let UNBLOCK discard what is owed.

Caution

Step 4 is not optional. A truncated burst leaves the peripheral mid-transfer, expecting beats that will never arrive. Only a reset clears that state.

Transactions attempted while the core is blocked are answered with an error, not stalled. There is no window in which the firewall quietly holds traffic until recovery completes, so every transaction issued between the fault and the recovery has failed.

Drivers for peripherals behind this core need a retry path.

Note that clearing STATUS.TIMEOUT_ERROR releases the auto-isolate latch but does **not** reopen the downstream. Acknowledging a fault must not accidentally restart traffic toward a peripheral nobody has reset.

3.8 Interrupts

irq is a level interrupt, asserted while any sticky STATUS bit in [3:0] is set *and* its corresponding IRQ_ENABLE bit is set. It is cleared by clearing the source: write 1 to the relevant STATUS bit. This is the standard Avalon-MM peripheral idiom and works directly with the Nios II HAL ISR pattern.

Unmasking an already-latched fault asserts irq immediately; the enable is a mask on the output, not on the latching.

FAULT_ADDR and FAULT_INFO form a single shared latch, updated by each new fault.

Note

Read `FAULT_ADDR` and `FAULT_INFO` *before* acknowledging. Acknowledging reopens the core to traffic that can fault again immediately and overwrite them.

If a read fault and a write fault occur in the same cycle, both sticky bits are set correctly, but `FAULT_ADDR` and `FAULT_INFO` capture the write side. This is a documented, deterministic tie-break.

3.9 Control Port Behaviour

`csr` is deliberately the simplest possible Avalon-MM agent: 32-bit, word-addressed, fixed read latency of 1, and it never asserts `waitrequest`. It has no outstanding-transaction state that could get stuck, which is what makes it trivially safe to reach while the data path is isolated or wedged.

Note

`csr` is **word-addressed** — Platform Designer's default `addressUnits` for an Avalon-MM agent. All offsets in [Section 6](#) are byte offsets, which is what software uses; the interconnect performs the divide-by-four. You do not need to scale anything in your driver.

Byte enables are honoured on `csr` writes, including partial writes to `RULE_BASE`, `RULE_LIMIT` and `TIMEOUT_VALUE`.

The control port is not affected by the firewall's own rules, by `MANUAL_ISOLATE`, or by a blocked downstream.

3.10 Reset

`reset_n` is active-low and synchronous to `clk`. All state is cleared, including the entire rule table, so the core comes out of reset in default-deny with access control enabled and auto-isolate enabled.

Reset asserted mid-burst is safe on both channels: the beat counters clear and the port is immediately usable again.

Caution

Resetting the *firewall* does not reset the *peripheral*. If a burst was in flight, the peripheral is left mid-transfer and must be reset too — the same requirement as step 4 of the recovery sequence.

3.11 Latency and Throughput

Measured by the benchmark in the regression suite, against a zero-wait-state peripheral model:

Operation	Cycles	In-suite guard
32-beat write burst	33	fails above 36
32-beat read burst, command to last beat	36	fails above 40

That is one beat per cycle plus the peripheral's own read latency. **The core adds no cycles of its own.** The guards are part of the regression, so these numbers cannot silently regress.

Refused transactions are answered at one beat per cycle after a one-cycle acceptance, and never touch the peripheral.

4. Parameters

Parameter	Default	Range	HDL	Description
ADDR_WIDTH	32	8–32	Yes	Byte address width of <code>s0</code> and <code>m0</code> . <code>RULE_BASE / RULE_LIMIT</code> are this wide
DATA_WIDTH	32	8–1024, power of two	Yes	Data width of <code>s0</code> and <code>m0</code>
BURST_WIDTH	8	1–11	Yes	Width of <code>burstcount</code> . Maximum burst is $2^{(\text{BURST_WIDTH} - 1)}$ beats. 1 means non-bursting
MAX_PENDING_READS	4	1–32	Yes	Read bursts trackable at once. Sets the outstanding-beat budget and is published to Platform Designer on both ports
NUM_RULES	8	1–64	Yes	Number of address windows
TIMEOUT_WIDTH	20	8–32	Yes	Maximum programmable timeout is $2^{\text{TIMEOUT_WIDTH} - 1}$ cycles
CSR_ADDR_WIDTH	8	5–16	Yes	Control port address width, in words
USE_RESPONSE	1	0, 1	No	Expose the 2-bit <code>response</code> signal on <code>s0</code> and <code>m0</code>
USE_WRITE_RESPONSE	0	0, 1	Yes	Expose <code>writeresponsevalid</code> . Requires <code>USE_RESPONSE</code>
REGISTER_LOOKUP	0	0, 1	Yes	Register the rule lookup, breaking the combinational path from the rule table to the verdict. Costs one cycle per transaction, not per beat

Choosing values

`BURST_WIDTH` should match the master in front of the firewall. A Nios II/f data master with a data cache bursts up to its line length; an mSGDMA commonly uses up to 128 beats, which is `BURST_WIDTH = 8`. Making it larger than necessary only widens the range comparators.

`NUM_RULES` is the main cost and timing driver. Use the smallest number that covers your address map.

`CSR_ADDR_WIDTH` is in words, and must cover word $0x10 + \text{NUM_RULES} \times 4$ — that is, byte $0x40 + \text{NUM_RULES} \times 16$.

`TIMEOUT_VALUE` (the register, not a parameter) should be a few times the worst legitimate stall of the protected peripheral. Because the counter measures cycles without progress, it does not need scaling by burst length.

Validation

Three configurations elaborate, simulate and are quietly wrong. `hw.tcl` rejects all three at generation time:

Check	Why it matters
<code>CSR_ADDR_WIDTH</code> covers the whole rule table	Otherwise high-index rules are silently unreachable and appear to be permanently invalid
$\text{ADDR_WIDTH} \geq \text{BURST_WIDTH} - 1 + \log_2(\text{DATA_WIDTH} / 8)$	Otherwise a single maximum-length burst can span the entire address space and the range check stops meaning anything
<code>USE_WRITE_RESPONSE</code> implies <code>USE_RESPONSE</code>	<code>writeresponsevalid</code> qualifies <code>response</code> ; without <code>response</code> there is nothing to qualify

The component also emits informational messages when `USE_RESPONSE` is disabled, and when `BURST_WIDTH` is 1 and the burst machinery therefore has no effect.

5. Interface Signals

5.1 Clock and Reset

Signal	Direction	Width	Description
clk	Input	1	Clock for all three interfaces
reset_n	Input	1	Active-low synchronous reset

5.2 s0 — Avalon-MM Agent (data path)

Byte-addressed (addressUnits SYMBOLS), bursting, variable read latency.

Signal	Direction	Width	Description
s0_address	Input	ADDR_WIDTH	Byte address. Valid with the first beat of a burst
s0_read	Input	1	Read command
s0_write	Input	1	Write command
s0_writedata	Input	DATA_WIDTH	Write data
s0_byteenable	Input	DATA_WIDTH / 8	Byte enables, forwarded unmodified
s0_burstcount	Input	BURST_WIDTH	Beats in this burst, in words
s0_waitrequest	Output	1	Stall. May be combinational dependent on read / write
s0_readdata	Output	DATA_WIDTH	Read data. Zero on refused reads
s0_readdatavalid	Output	1	Qualifies s0_readdata
s0_response	Output	2	Present when USE_RESPONSE = 1
s0_writeresponsevalid	Output	1	Present when USE_WRITE_RESPONSE = 1

5.3 m0 — Avalon-MM Host (data path)

Byte-addressed, bursting, variable read latency. Mirrors s0 .

Signal	Direction	Width	Description
m0_address	Output	ADDR_WIDTH	
m0_read	Output	1	
m0_write	Output	1	
m0_writedata	Output	DATA_WIDTH	
m0_byteenable	Output	DATA_WIDTH / 8	
m0_burstcount	Output	BURST_WIDTH	
m0_waitrequest	Input	1	
m0_readdata	Input	DATA_WIDTH	
m0_readdatavalid	Input	1	Ignored unless beats are owed
m0_response	Input	2	Present when USE_RESPONSE = 1
m0_writeresponsevalid	Input	1	Present when USE_WRITE_RESPONSE = 1

5.4 csr — Avalon-MM Agent (control and status)

Word-addressed, 32-bit, fixed read latency 1, no waitrequest .

Signal	Direction	Width	Description
csr_address	Input	CSR_ADDR_WIDTH	Word address
csr_read	Input	1	
csr_write	Input	1	
csr_writedata	Input	32	
csr_byteenable	Input	4	Honoured on all writable registers
csr_readdata	Output	32	Valid one cycle after csr_read

5.5 Interrupt

Signal	Direction	Width	Description
irq	Output	1	Level interrupt, associated with csr

6. Register Map

All offsets are **byte** offsets from the `csr` base address, which is what software uses. The hardware port is word-addressed; the interconnect handles the conversion.

Offset	Name	Access	Reset
0x00	CTRL	R/W	0x0000_0003
0x04	STATUS	R / W1C on [3:0]	0x0000_0000
0x08	IRQ_ENABLE	R/W	0x0000_000F
0x0C	TIMEOUT_VALUE	R/W	all-ones
0x10	FAULT_ADDR	R	0x0000_0000
0x14	FAULT_INFO	R	0x0000_0000
0x18	CORE_INFO	R	build-dependent
0x1C	RECOVERY	W	—
0x40 + i·0x10	RULE_BASE[i]	R/W	0x0000_0000
0x44 + i·0x10	RULE_LIMIT[i]	R/W	0x0000_0000
0x48 + i·0x10	RULE_PERM[i]	R/W	0x0000_0000

`i` runs from 0 to `NUM_RULES - 1`. With the default of 8 rules the table spans 0x40 to 0xBF.

csr register map — byte offsets

The port is word-addressed in hardware; the interconnect does the divide-by-four, so software uses these offsets directly.

Offset	Name	Access	Purpose
0x00	CTRL	R/W	enable, auto-isolate, manual isolate
0x04	STATUS	R / W1C	four sticky faults, six live status bits
0x08	IRQ_ENABLE	R/W	one mask bit per sticky fault
0x0C	TIMEOUT_VALUE	R/W	cycles WITHOUT PROGRESS before giving up
0x10	FAULT_ADDR	R	start address of the latched fault
0x14	FAULT_INFO	R	direction, cause, burst length
0x18	CORE_INFO	R	generated parameters and version
0x1C	RECOVERY	W	UNBLOCK — the one authorised discard
0x40+i·0x10	RULE_BASE[i]	R/W	first byte of window i, inclusive
0x44+i·0x10	RULE_LIMIT[i]	R/W	last byte of window i, inclusive
0x48+i·0x10	RULE_PERM[i]	R/W	read / write / valid / burst

CTRL (0x00)

31:3 reserved	2 MANUAL_ISOLATE	1 AUTO_ISOLATE_EN reset 1	0 GLOBAL_ENABLE reset 1
-------------------------	----------------------------	-------------------------------------	-----------------------------------

STATUS (0x04) — bits 3:0 sticky, write 1 to clear

9:8 RDWR_CMD_STUCK	7:6 RDWR_BUSY	5 BLOCKED	4 ISOLATED	3 BURST_VIOLATION	2:0 TIMEOUT, PERM, ADDR
------------------------------	-------------------------	---------------------	----------------------	-----------------------------	-----------------------------------

FAULT_INFO (0x14)

31:16 reserved	15:8 BURSTCOUNT saturating	7:4 reserved	3:1 1=ADDR 2=PERM 3=TIMEOUT 4=BURST_RANGE 5=BURST_DENIED	0 WAS_WRITE
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RULE_PERM[i] (0x48 + i·0x10)

31:4 reserved	3 BURST_ALLOW	2 VALID	1 WRITE_ALLOW	0 READ_ALLOW
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CORE_INFO (0x18)

31:16 version 0x0100 = v1.0	15:13 log2 bytes/beat	12:8 BURST_WIDTH	7:0 NUM_RULES
---------------------------------------	---------------------------------	----------------------------	-------------------------

Figure 6. Register map

6.1 CTRL (0x00)

Bit	Name	Access	Reset	Description
0	GLOBAL_ENABLE	R/W	1	1 = enforce the rule table. 0 = bypass the rule check. Does not disable fault isolation
1	AUTO_ISOLATE_EN	R/W	1	1 = a timeout also sets STATUS.ISOLATED
2	MANUAL_ISOLATE	R/W	0	1 = refuse all data-path traffic
31:3	—	R	0	Reserved

Both enables reset **set**: the core is secure by default.

6.2 STATUS (0x04)

Bits [3:0] are sticky and write-1-to-clear. Bits [9:4] are live and read-only.

Bit	Name	Access	Description
0	ADDR_VIOLATION	W1C	An access hit no valid window
1	PERM_VIOLATION	W1C	A window matched but did not permit the direction
2	TIMEOUT_ERROR	W1C	The peripheral stopped making progress. Clearing also releases auto-isolate, but does not unblock
3	BURST_VIOLATION	W1C	A burst overran its window, or the window forbids bursts. FAULT_INFO.TYPE distinguishes the two
4	ISOLATED	R	MANUAL_ISOLATE or the auto-isolate latch is set
5	BLOCKED	R	Forwarding is refused. Only RECOVERY.UNBLOCK clears this
6	WR_BUSY	R	A forwarded write is outstanding downstream
7	RD_BUSY	R	Read beats are owed by the peripheral
8	WR_CMD_STUCK	R	A frozen write command is being held
9	RD_CMD_STUCK	R	A frozen read command is being held
31:10	—	R	Reserved

6.3 IRQ_ENABLE (0x08)

Bit	Name	Reset	Description
0	ADDR_IRQ_EN	1	
1	PERM_IRQ_EN	1	
2	TIMEOUT_IRQ_EN	1	
3	BURST_IRQ_EN	1	
31:4	—	0	Reserved

Positions correspond one-to-one with STATUS[3:0].

6.4 TIMEOUT_VALUE (0x0C)

`TIMEOUT_WIDTH` bits. The number of clock cycles without progress before a forwarded transaction is abandoned. Resets to all-ones, which for the default `TIMEOUT_WIDTH` of 20 is over a million cycles and effectively disables the timeout until software sets it.

6.5 FAULT_ADDR (0x10)

Read-only. The **start address** of the transaction that caused the most recently latched fault — not the address of the offending beat within a burst.

6.6 FAULT_INFO (0x14)

Bit	Name	Description
0	<code>WAS_WRITE</code>	1 = the fault came from a write, 0 = from a read
3:1	<code>TYPE</code>	1 = ADDR, 2 = PERM, 3 = TIMEOUT, 4 = BURST_RANGE, 5 = BURST_DENIED
7:4	—	Reserved
15:8	<code>BURSTCOUNT</code>	Burst length of the faulting transaction, saturating at 255
31:16	—	Reserved

`BURSTCOUNT` saturates rather than truncating: a 256-beat burst reading back as 0 would be worse than useless in a field whose entire purpose is to say how large the offending transfer was.

6.7 CORE_INFO (0x18)

Read-only. Describes the hardware as generated.

Bit	Name	Description
7:0	<code>NUM_RULES</code>	Number of rule slots
12:8	<code>BURST_WIDTH</code>	Width of <code>burstcount</code> ; maximum burst is $2^{(\text{value}-1)}$ beats
15:13	<code>BEAT_SHIFT</code>	log2 of bytes per beat
31:16	<code>VERSION</code>	0x0100 for v1.0

Drivers should check `VERSION` before using any other register.

6.8 RECOVERY (0x1C)

Write-only, self-clearing; reads as 0.

Bit	Name	Description
0	<code>UNBLOCK</code>	Declares downstream state discarded: releases <code>STATUS.BLOCKED</code> and withdraws any frozen <code>m0</code> command

Caution

`UNBLOCK` is the only point at which the core will drop a command whose `waitrequest` handshake never completed. Issuing it without having reset the protected peripheral is a protocol violation on a live bus.

6.9 RULE_BASE[i], RULE_LIMIT[i], RULE_PERM[i]

RULE_BASE and RULE_LIMIT are ADDR_WIDTH-bit byte addresses, both inclusive.

RULE_PERM[i] :

Bit	Name	Description
0	READ_ALLOW	
1	WRITE_ALLOW	
2	VALID	The window is ignored entirely when clear
3	BURST_ALLOW	burstcount > 1 permitted
31:4	—	Reserved

Caution

A window is described by three registers, so updating a **live** window leaves a transient in which the base is new and the limit is still old. Always clear **VALID** first when reconfiguring an active window. At initialisation this is unnecessary — **VALID** is 0 out of reset.

7. Software Programming Model

A Nios II HAL driver is provided, laid out as a standard Altera component so the BSP finds it without any manual copying:

```
altera_avalon_mm_firewall/
├─ avl_mm_firewall_sw.tcl          driver description
├─ inc/altera_avalon_mm_firewall_regs.h  register map, <io.h> only
├─ HAL/
│   ├─ inc/altera_avalon_mm_firewall.h  driver API
│   └─ src/altera_avalon_mm_firewall.c  driver
```

`nios2-bsp-generate-files` scans the IP search path for `*_sw.tcl` and matches each one's `hw_class_name` against the component's `_hw.tcl NAME`. Add the component to your system, regenerate the BSP, and the driver is compiled into it with the headers on the include path.

Note

`inc/altera_avalon_mm_firewall_regs.h` is self-contained. If you want nothing but the register offsets — for a bare-metal loader, or a different processor — include it alone; it needs only `<io.h>`.

7.1 Automatic initialisation

The driver sets `auto_initialize`, so the BSP emits this into `alt_sys_init.c` for every instance in the system:

```
ALTERA_AVALON_MM_FIREWALL_INSTANCE(FIREWALL_0, firewall_0);
...
ALTERA_AVALON_MM_FIREWALL_INIT(FIREWALL_0, firewall_0);
```

`alt_sys_init()` runs before `main()`. It takes the base address and interrupt numbers from `system.h`, checks `CORE_INFO.VERSION`, reads the rule count, maximum burst and bytes per beat back out of the hardware, and registers the interrupt.

It deliberately does **not** program the rule table and does **not** install the peripheral-reset callbacks, because neither can be derived from the hardware. That division is the safe one: the table resets empty and the hardware is default-deny, so the state after `alt_sys_init()` is "everything denied" — which is exactly what should be true while the application is still starting up.

Caution

Registering the interrupt before the reset callbacks exist is intentional — an early fault is then acknowledged rather than left asserting a level interrupt forever. `alt_avalon_mm_firewall_recover()` declines safely (returning `-1`) until the callbacks are installed.

7.2 Application initialisation

```
#include "altera_avalon_mm_firewall.h"

/* Defined by alt_sys_init.c, which the BSP generates. */
extern alt_avalon_mm_firewall_dev firewall_0;

static void periph_assert_reset(void *ctx) { /* drive the peripheral's reset low */ }
static void periph_release_reset(void *ctx) { /* drive the peripheral's reset high */ }

static const alt_avalon_mm_firewall_rule my_map[] = {
    /* control registers: CPU may read and write; no bursting */
    { 0x00010000u, 0x000100FFu, ALT_AVMM_FW_PERM_READ | ALT_AVMM_FW_PERM_WRITE },
    /* sample buffer: DMA may burst-read; nobody may write */
    { 0x00020000u, 0x0002FFFFu, ALT_AVMM_FW_PERM_READ | ALT_AVMM_FW_PERM_BURST },
};

void firewall_setup(void)
{
    alt_avalon_mm_firewall_set_reset_handlers(&firewall_0, periph_assert_reset,
                                              periph_release_reset, NULL);

    alt_avalon_mm_firewall_configure(&firewall_0, my_map, 2);
    alt_avalon_mm_firewall_set_timeout(&firewall_0, 50000);
}
```

`configure()` programs the windows you describe **and retires every unused rule slot**. A stale rule left valid from a previous configuration is an open window nobody remembers opening.

Note what initialisation does *not* do: it never writes `CTRL`. The core resets with access control and auto-isolate enabled, and the interval between reset and the first `configure()` call is exactly when default-deny should be in force.

7.3 Reconfiguring a live window

```
alt_avalon_mm_firewall_set_rule(&firewall_0, 2, 0x00030000u, 0x0003FFFFu,
                                ALT_AVMM_FW_PERM_READ | ALT_AVMM_FW_PERM_BURST);
```

The driver clears `VALID` first, writes base and limit, then writes the permissions with `VALID` set. Doing it in any other order leaves a window describing a range nobody intended, live on the bus, for a few cycles.

7.4 Interrupt service

```
alt_u32 status = IORD_ALTERA_AVALON_MM_FIREWALL_STATUS(base);
if (status & ALTERA_AVALON_MM_FIREWALL_STATUS_STICKY_MSK) {
    alt_u32 addr = IORD_ALTERA_AVALON_MM_FIREWALL_FAULT_ADDR(base);
    alt_u32 info = IORD_ALTERA_AVALON_MM_FIREWALL_FAULT_INFO(base);

    /* ... log addr, ALTERA_AVALON_MM_FIREWALL_FAULT_TYPE(info), ... */

    IOWR_ALTERA_AVALON_MM_FIREWALL_STATUS(
        base, status & ALTERA_AVALON_MM_FIREWALL_STATUS_STICKY_MSK);

    if (status & ALTERA_AVALON_MM_FIREWALL_STATUS_TIMEOUT_MSK)
        alt_avalon_mm_firewall_recover(&firewall_0);
}
```

Read the fault registers **before** acknowledging: they are a single shared latch, and acknowledging reopens the core to traffic that can fault again immediately.

7.5 Recovery

`alt_avalon_mm_firewall_recover()` implements the sequence in [Section 3.7](#), including the bounded busy poll and the `UNBLOCK`-inside-reset ordering. It returns `-1` if no reset callbacks were supplied, because without them recovery cannot be completed and reporting success would be a lie.

Recovery resets a peripheral, so in most systems it does not belong in an ISR. Set a flag and let a thread call it.

7.6 Retry

Transactions attempted while the core was blocked were answered with an error, not stalled. Anything issued between the fault and the completion of recovery has failed and must be retried by whoever issued it.

8. Verification

8.1 Test suite

`tb/avl_mm_firewall_tb.sv` is self-checking and needs no Quartus licence. It runs under Verilator (`--timing --assert`), Questa, and Icarus (`-g2012`, with `-DICARUS` to omit the assertion bind).

The suite runs four times: `USE_WRITE_RESPONSE` 0 and 1, each with `REGISTER_LOOKUP` 0 and 1. Write responses change the write channel's completion rule — last beat accepted, versus peripheral answered — and with it the timeout scope, the abandonment path and the arbitration of the shared `response` signal against read data. Running only the default leaves half the write channel unexercised.

Result: 632 checks pass — each of the four runs is 153 checks with write responses disabled or 163 with them enabled. Zero assertion failures, zero `m0` protocol violations, and every one of the 20 assertions has a non-zero pass count, so none of them is passing vacuously.

Coverage includes:

- Single and burst reads and writes with data integrity, up to the maximum 128-beat burst
- Burst throughput, with regression guards
- Permission denial in **both** directions, including reads from a write-only window
- Unmapped addresses on both channels
- Burst straddle on both channels, with an explicit watcher proving `m0` is never touched
- Adjacent permitted windows not merging
- Per-window burst capability, with the window's contents proven untouched after a refused burst
- Three pipelined read bursts returning in issue order
- Wait states on the downstream peripheral
- Read timeout with the command never accepted, and separately with the command accepted and the peripheral then silent — different branches
- Write timeout with the command never accepted, and separately with every beat accepted and only the write response withheld — the second reaches the write-response arm of the abandonment logic and nothing else does
- Acknowledgement proven *not* to unblock; the frozen command proven to survive the peripheral reset and to be withdrawn only by `UNBLOCK`
- Orphan beats after recovery discarded
- Manual isolation, bypass mode, and bypass not reopening a broken downstream
- Interrupt masking, including unmasking an already-latched fault
- Rule reprogramming, and the vacated address becoming unmapped again
- Byte enables on the data path and on `csr`
- Read-only registers, unmapped offsets, reserved words in a rule slot
- Reset asserted mid-burst, swept across four offsets

8.2 Assertions

`tb/avl_mm_firewall_sva.sv` binds **22 assertions and 11 cover points** into `avl_mm_firewall_top`, in three groups.

Group	Properties
Protocol	<code>m0_read / m0_write</code> never concurrent; commands held until <code>waitrequest</code> falls, with <code>UNBLOCK</code> the single exception; frozen commands hold address and burstcount; <code>burstcount</code> never zero; <code>readdatavalid</code> and <code>writeresponsevalid</code> never coincide
Security	refused transactions never leak a command to <code>m0</code> ; nothing new issued while blocked; the block latches until <code>UNBLOCK</code>
Liveness	every beat presented upstream is one the core owes; orphan beats dropped; refused reads never stalled and always drain; refused writes never stalled

The liveness group is specific to Avalon-MM. On AXI a slave can refuse; here it can only answer, so every rejection path needs proving that it does.

All 11 cover points are hit, with counts measured across both parameterisations. Three of them started at zero and are the reason the suite grew: the permission-denied *read*, the *write*-side burst straddle, and an unblock that had to discard a frozen command. The third turned out to be a design problem rather than a missing test — it is why steps 5 and 6 of the recovery sequence are in the order they are.

Note

Read assertion *pass* counts, not just failure counts. A property that only ever passes vacuously has verified nothing while looking green. Non-vacuous pass counts require the Questa flow.

8.3 Static checks

Every run of `simulation/verilator/run_sim.sh` also performs:

- **Strict LRM elaboration** with slang, which rejects use-before-declaration and implicit-net collisions that other front ends silently resolve — the class of problem that shows up much later as a Questa compile failure. **0 errors.**
- **RTL lint** at `-Wall` with nothing waived. **Clean.**
- **The same lint across five parameter configurations**, spanning `DATA_WIDTH` 8 to 256, `BURST_WIDTH` 1 to 11, `NUM_RULES` 1 to 64. The burst range check, the beat counters and the `FAULT_INFO` saturation are all parameter-sized, and the combinations most likely to break are the ones nobody simulates. **All clean.**

9. Design Considerations and Limitations

9.1 Known limitations

Limitation	Detail
No per-master filtering	Avalon-MM carries no master identity, so access control is address plus direction only. Per-master filtering would need a sideband ID signal
Wrapping bursts not supported	Both interfaces declare <code>linewrapBursts false</code> . Platform Designer inserts an adapter if a master requires them
One refused read burst at a time	No new read is accepted while a refusal is draining. This is what satisfies in-order read response without a reorder buffer. Refusals are errors, so the throughput cost is irrelevant; permitted reads pipeline freely
Rule lookup is combinational	All <code>NUM_RULES</code> comparators are in the critical path. If <code>Fmax</code> suffers, a pipeline stage on the lookup is the standard fix, costing one cycle per transaction — amortised across a burst
Recovery needs a peripheral reset the core does not own	See Section 2.3
No transaction is stalled during recovery	Traffic during a block is answered with an error, so drivers need a retry path
Truncated bursts reach the peripheral	An abandoned forwarded burst leaves the peripheral mid-transfer. Unavoidable; it is why the reset is mandatory

9.2 What has not been verified

Item	Status
Synthesis results, <code>Fmax</code> , resource usage	Not measured
Behaviour in a real Platform Designer system	Not verified end to end. The testbench models a well-behaved bursting peripheral, not generated interconnect
<code>hw.tcl</code> import into a specific Quartus release	Not verified — see Section 2.1
Assertion non-vacuity	Requires the Questa flow; not quoted here
Device family support	Not characterised on hardware

9.3 Security considerations

The firewall polices what crosses it. It does not, and cannot:

- distinguish which master issued a transaction;
- protect against a master that reaches the peripheral by another path — if the peripheral has a second Avalon-MM agent port, or another master is connected to it directly, the firewall is bypassed at the system level;
- protect the `csr` port itself. Any master connected to `csr` can reprogram the rule table. In a system with a security boundary, `csr` should be reachable only from the trusted master.

9.4 Choosing between this core and the AXI4-Lite firewall

	<code>altera_avalon_mm_firewall</code>	<code>altera_axi4_lite_firewall</code>
Protocol	Avalon-MM	AXI4-Lite
Bursts	Yes, up to 1024 beats	No
Latency added, permitted transaction	0 cycles	6 cycles per transaction
Suitable for a DMA engine	Yes	No
Per-window burst permission	Yes	n/a
Native for Nios II / mSGDMA	Yes	Requires interconnect bridging

Use this core unless you specifically need an AXI4-Lite interface.

10. Document Revision History

Document version	Core version	Date	Changes
1.0	1.0	August 2026	Initial release